# “If I say no, people will reject me.”

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## Where it often comes from

If love was conditional in our family, or if saying no brought anger, sulking, or punishment, we learned that refusal is dangerous. As adults we say yes to avoid conflict, and then feel resentful, overextended, and unsure whether anyone likes us for who we are.

## What Scripture teaches

Jesus said, “Simply let your ‘Yes’ be ‘Yes,’ and your ‘No,’ ‘No.’” Paul writes, “Am I now seeking the approval of men, or of God?” Proverbs says, “The fear of man is a snare, but whoever trusts in the LORD is set securely on high.” Jesus “frequently withdrew to the wilderness to pray,” and “early in the morning, while it was still dark, Jesus got up and slipped out to a solitary place to pray,” even when people wanted Him. A kind no is not a rejection of the person, and people who truly care will usually adjust.

> *“Simply let your ‘Yes’ be ‘Yes,’ and your ‘No,’ ‘No.’ Anything more comes from the evil one”* (Matthew 5:37).

## Also see

> “Am I now seeking the approval of men, or of God? Or am I striving to please men? If I were still trying to please men, I would not be a servant of Christ” (Galatians 1:10).

> “The fear of man is a snare, but whoever trusts in the LORD is set securely on high” (Proverbs 29:25).

> “Yet He frequently withdrew to the wilderness to pray” (Luke 5:16).

> “Early in the morning, while it was still dark, Jesus got up and slipped out to a solitary place to pray” (Mark 1:35).

## Common self-statements

- If I say no, they will be angry or leave.
- I will lose my friends.
- Saying no is mean.
- I cannot disappoint anyone.
- People only like me when I say yes.
- Conflict will follow.

## Common logical errors

- Fortune telling: Predicting rejection if I say no.
- Mind reading: Assuming I know how they will react.
- Catastrophizing: Imagining total loss after one refusal.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling anxious and concluding that no is dangerous.

## Challenging questions

- What happened when I said no growing up?
- When have I said no and the relationship survived?

- What does constant yes cost me?
- What is a kind, clear no that I could practice?
- Who would stay if I said no?
- What would God say about my need to please?

## Truth summary

> A kind no is not a rejection. People who love me can handle my limits, and God does not ask me to please everyone. I can say no gently and clearly and trust God with the response.

## Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Fear
- Communication
- Self-Esteem, Low
- Wisdom
- Trust

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Communication
- Anxiety/Worry/Fear

## Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

## Songs that speak truth to this belief

Voice of Truth — Casting Crowns
Test accusing or frightening messages against God's truth.

You Say — Lauren Daigle
God's loving assessment challenges identity based only on weakness or feelings.

Just Be Held — Casting Crowns
God's care remains when control, strength, or explanations run out.

Blessed Assurance — Larry Ford and Lillie Knauls with Gaither
This classic hymn celebrates belonging to Christ and resting in His salvation.

*Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"*

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

# My Plan for Replacing "If I say no, people will reject me"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

## 1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

*Rate it now so you can see your progress later.*

"If I say no, people will reject me." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

## 2 My best question

*The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.*

- ☐ What happened when I said no?
- ☐ What does yes cost me?
- ☐ What is a kind no?
- ☐ Who would stay?
- ☐ What is God's view?
- ☐ What will I practice?

My own question: _____

## 3 My replacement truth

*The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.*

- ☐ My yes can be yes and my no can be no.
- ☐ The fear of man is a snare.
- ☐ Jesus withdrew to pray.
- ☐ Healthy people accept limits.
- ☐ I can be kind and clear.
- ☐ I seek God's approval.

In my own words: _____

## 4 My Scripture

*The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.*

- ☐ **Matthew 5:37**
  *"Simply let your 'Yes' be 'Yes,' and your 'No,' 'No.' Anything more comes from the evil one."*
- ☐ **Galatians 1:10**
  *"Am I now seeking the approval of men, or of God? Or am I striving to please men? If I were still trying to please men, I would not be a servant of Christ."*
- ☐ **Luke 5:16**
  *"Yet He frequently withdrew to the wilderness to pray."*

A verse I found myself: _____

_____

# Practicing the Truth

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## 5 My practice plan

*Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.*

### EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- ☐ Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- ☐ Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

### PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ A kind no: Each week, record a no you said and how the relationship fared.
- ☐ My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  *For example, Matthew 5:37 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I can let my yes be yes and my no be no.""*
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ Reading: The "Fear" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

## 6 My action step this week

*Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.*

*Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.*

- ☐ Practice a script. Write: "Thank you for asking. I can't this time."
- ☐ Start small. Say no to a low-stakes request.
- ☐ Notice the result. Record what actually happened.
- ☐ Withdraw to pray. Take time alone to hear God.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

## 7 End-of-week check-in

*Bring this page to your next session.*

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "If I say no, people will reject me": _____ %  My truth: _____ %

## Daily practice tracker

| Day | Read my card | Said my verse | Used my reminder | A kind no |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Mon | | | | |
| Tue | | | | |
| Wed | | | | |
| Thu | | | | |
| Fri | | | | |
| Sat | | | | |
| Sun | | | | |

## My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

| Day | Song I listened to | What it told me that challenges the lie |
|---|---|---|
| Mon | | |
| Tue | | |
| Wed | | |
| Thu | | |
| Fri | | |
| Sat | | |
| Sun | | |

## My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~If I say no, people will reject me.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

*Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.*

## Prayer

*Father, I fear disappointing people. Teach me to be kind and clear, to say yes and no with honesty, and to rest in Your approval. Amen.*

*Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.*